STRIFE & SERENITY

MARA’S DISAPPEARANCE

INT. MARA'S ROOM — DAY

Mara's bed is unmade. Her closet is nearly empty, and her belongings lie scattered around the room. Ka'Sipho sits nearby while Veydrin looks the place over.

KA'SIPHO

I'll go over it one more time.

When she woke up, she woke me up too.

I didn't wanna let her know, or she would've kept on apologizing for the rest of the day.

You know her. She's sweet like that.

So, I just kept my eyes closed to play it off. I could still tell she was looking at me.

But then after her whole ramble, I heard... crying?

Or at least I thought it was. It was stifled, so I couldn't make it out.

If I knew she'd just... VANISH out of the blue like this, I would've gotten up and checked on her, I swear...

Apologizing all day and all.

Ka'Sipho looks down. Neither speaks for a moment.

KA'SIPHO

Look, that's all I know. Can you go now?

VEYDRIN

Not just yet, Ka'Sipho.

Veydrin glances from the unmade bed to the empty closet.

VEYDRIN

She couldn't have done all this in her right mind...

I'm defying orders by even being here.

KA'SIPHO

So not all ZARIMAR are spineless. Good to know.

Veydrin pauses at the insult, then lets it pass.

VEYDRIN

The truth is, most of High Command thinks that you're naive, that you're too naive to BELIEVE you're naive, and on top of all that, stubborn.

KA'SIPHO

Naive? The hell I am!

VEYDRIN

Exhibit A.

Something happened to Mara. Something that started this spiral.

KA'SIPHO

And you think I had something to do with that??

VEYDRIN

Quite the opposite.

She hasn't been the same since her last mission. I want to know what it is that's wrong with her. Whatever it is, she'll talk to you over any of us. That makes you the key.

KA'SIPHO

You don't even know where she's at NOW...

VEYDRIN

Well, we have reason to believe she was at the Verse-Gates this morning.

KA'SIPHO

Why?

VEYDRIN

No idea.

But either way, what do you say?

KA'SIPHO

I say that you're out of luck. We're close, but if Mara doesn't WANT to be found, she won't be. It's how she's always been.

VEYDRIN

With you, I find that hard to believe.

KA'SIPHO

What's that supposed to mean...?

VEYDRIN

Exhibit B.

I'll bet C's just around the corner.

KA'SIPHO

What does that even— cut that out!!

Besides, you still didn't answer my first question. Why's everyone and their mother out looking for her?

She miss 'roll call' or something?

VEYDRIN

I really, really wish that were the case.

No, she's wanted for the murder of 13 soldiers.

Ka'Sipho freezes. He stares at Veydrin, waiting for him to take it back.

KA'SIPHO

Yeah, sure she is, Veydrin...

VEYDRIN

It's the truth.

KA'SIPHO

More like desperation.

VEYDRIN

Desp— What the hell're you saying..?

KA'SIPHO

This is another ploy to try and get me to join the ZARIMAR. I should've smelled it from a mile away.

Just didn't think you'd be scummy enough to lie abou—

VEYDRIN

Don't...

Veydrin's voice cuts through the room. Ka'Sipho stops.

VEYDRIN

...you EVER accuse me of lying. Not when it comes to the lives of my brothers and sisters.

KA'SIPHO

O...kay?

Veydrin rarely loses his composure. Ka'Sipho doesn't know what to make of it.

VEYDRIN

I'm tired of you talking down on us.

NONE of us want to fight. ALL of us would throw down our weapons in an instant if we could.

But you know as well as I do, that IT wins if we do.

We CANNOT let that happen.

That very reason is why I take pride in what I do. Helping the ZARIMAR stay strong in body and sharp in mind. But right now?

Mara is anything but the latter.

Duty doesn't leave room for many luxuries, but it comes with purpose, which is one I choose to hold on to.

We fight for PEACE. The Creator chose us to guide the Uni-Verse towards it and it's why the ZARIMAR exist now so that one day it no longer HAS to.

But YOU would rather piss away your life and play the antimilitarist. It's pathetic as it is depressing.

KA'SIPHO

I- I'm NOT—

VEYDRIN

Be quiet.

There are 13 dead ZARIMAR, Ka'Sipho.

Not unconscious...

Nor incapacitated...

DEAD.

Now there's talk about Mara being CONFLICTED. Are you even aware of how serious this is??

KA'SIPHO

YES!

I just... I can't lose her too! OKAY!?

Veydrin falls silent. Ka'Sipho looks away, struggling to collect himself.

KA'SIPHO

Look, I...

I know some ZARIMAR protocol from overhearing her sometimes.

If she's CONFLICTED, it's basically a death sentence. 'Eliminate on Sight' orders won't be far behind, right?

VEYDRIN

Ka'Sipho.

Ka'Sipho lets out a small sigh.

VEYDRIN

I had trouble believing it myself.

But as ZARIMAR, when talk of CONFLICTED rises, disbelief is another luxury we don't have.

KA'SIPHO

When... I lost Zurie in The Bleed, I nearly lost myself.

Then it was Kayn and El'Siph when they got CONFLICTED and fled Zothar.

But it was Mara that helped me get back up. Every time.

'Keep moving forward'. I can't ever unhear it now.

Ka'Sipho rises.

KA'SIPHO

I'm no ZARIMAR, so disbelief is a luxury that I DO have...

...and that comes with freedom.

He starts for the door.

VEYDRIN

Where are you going?

KA'SIPHO

To see for myself.

Veydrin watches him leave.

VEYDRIN

And there it is.

REFLECTION

The 'Exhibit A' and 'Exhibit B' jokes are little callbacks running through Ka'Sipho and Veydrin's conversation. Veydrin even predicts an Exhibit C, but when Ka'Sipho finally makes up his mind, all he says is, 'And there it is.'. The choice to have him not spell it out was intentional, as the player can make that connection themselves, and it brings the conversation full circle after the argument gets so heated.

There's another callback surrounding the topic of luxuries: Veydrin states that as a member of the ZARIMAR, they can't afford the luxury of disbelief when something serious such as Mara’s disappearance and rumours of her being CONFLICTED surface. Ka'Sipho is quick to flip this around, because he isn't a ZARIMAR, he has the freedom to doubt what he's been told and see the truth for himself. They're both approaching Mara's situation from very different positions, even though they both want to help her.

I also wanted references to ‘The Bleed’, Zurie, Kayn and El'Siph to come up naturally rather than stop the scene for an explanation. Ka'Sipho knows these people and events already, but the player doesn't. This leaves a few questions hanging and hopefully makes them want to learn more about Zothar and its history.